PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #71 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

“I can control it. I can stop whenever I want.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

“I can stop whenever I want” often protects a person from having to look closely. If you are still in control, you do not have to tell anyone, see a doctor, or feel afraid. Sometimes the sentence is true for a while, and then it becomes the reason you do not ask for help after it stops being true. You are not a weak person if stopping is harder than you expected. Strength here looks like honesty, not like proving you can quit without anyone. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus says that if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed. That freedom is a gift, not a performance you stage to show you were never stuck. You can approach the throne of grace for help in time of need. Grace is sufficient in weakness. Your help comes from the Lord. Scripture does not mock a person who discovers they cannot stop as easily as they thought. It invites them to a freedom that does not depend on managing it alone.

> *“So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed”* (John 8:36).

Also see

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” (Hebrews 4:16).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come? My help comes from the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth” (Psalm 121:1–2).

> “Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring” (Proverbs 27:1).

Common self-statements

- I can quit any time, so this is not a problem.
- If I needed help, I would already have asked.
- People who need help are the ones who have really lost it. I have not.
- I will not tell anyone, because then it becomes real.
- God helps people who have already stopped.
- Admitting I need help means I am a failure.

Common logical errors

- Denial: Using “I can stop” to avoid looking at what stopping actually takes.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either you are fully in control or you are a failure.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling capable in a calm moment and calling that proof for every moment.
- Fortune telling: Deciding you will quit later, so today does not count.

Challenging questions

- When did I last stop as easily as this sentence says?
- What am I protecting by saying I can control it?
- Who would I trust with the truth if I did not have to impress them?
- Would I want a friend to keep this secret if they were me?
- What would asking for help look like this week, without quitting in a dangerous way on my own?
- What does “free indeed” mean if freedom is a gift?

Truth summary

> I do not have to prove I can stop alone. If this is harder than I thought, I can tell the truth and ask for help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

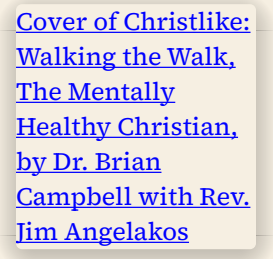
- Thinking, Healthy
- Help
- Trust
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Prayer
- Weak/Tired

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
You do not have to win this by yourself before you are allowed to ask for help.

Greater — MercyMe
God's help is greater than the claim that you can handle it alone.

Our God — Chris Tomlin
Needing God is not the same as being out of control as a person.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
Freedom is something Christ gives. It is not a test you have to pass in private.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can control it. I can stop whenever I want."

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can control it. I can stop whenever I want." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I last stop as easily as this sentence says?
- ☐ What am I protecting by saying I can control it?
- ☐ Who would I trust with the truth if I did not have to impress them?
- ☐ Would I want a friend to keep this secret if they were me?
- ☐ What would asking for help look like this week, without quitting in a dangerous way on my own?
- ☐ What does "free indeed" mean if freedom is a gift?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not have to prove I can stop alone. If this is harder than I thought, I can tell the truth and ask for help.
- ☐ Wanting to be in control is human.
- ☐ Honesty is stronger than a promise I keep only in my head.
- ☐ Needing a doctor or a counselor is not failure.
- ☐ Jesus offers real freedom. I do not have to manufacture it.
- ☐ I can ask for help before things get worse.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 8:36
  "So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed."
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When you said you could stop any time: Each day, write down one moment when you used control to avoid asking for help. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 8:36 becomes: "James can write: "I do not have to prove I can stop alone. Jesus is the one who sets people free.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- ☐ Tell one true sentence to a doctor, a counselor, or 1-800-662-4357: "Stopping is harder than I say."
- ☐ Do not test control by stopping suddenly if withdrawal could make you sick. Ask a doctor what is safe.
- ☐ Write the last time "I can stop whenever I want" was not what happened. No speech to yourself about being a failure.
- ☐ Pray John 8:36 as a request, not as a claim that you have already handled it.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can control it. I can stop whenever I want.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I told the truth about control
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can control it. I can stop whenever I want~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have said I can stop whenever I want. If that is no longer true, give me honesty and a safe way to get help. Set me free. Do not let me do this alone. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.